

Philadelphia's Academy Museum Closes Despite Offer of Temporary Funding

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The Academy of Natural Sciences museum in Philadelphia closed on September 30. The Academy was founded in 1812 and opened to the public in 1828. In 1868, it became the first place in the world to display a dinosaur skeleton.

For generations, visiting the museum has been a family tradition. When the closure was announced on September 1, thousands of families came for a final visit. Alexandria McCormick visited with her husband and six children. She said her childhood visits inspired her love of natural history, and she was sad that her children might not have similar experiences.

Drexel University took over financial responsibility for the Academy in 2011. Drexel said costs rose and attendance declined after the pandemic. During the museum's final weeks, however, attendance increased sharply and **revenue** was more than 20 times higher than last September.

Some supporters criticized Drexel for giving only one month's notice and for not explaining how much it would cost to keep the museum open. Drexel said it remained deeply committed to protecting the Academy's legacy.

The Academy holds more than 19 million scientific **specimens**. These are samples kept for study, including Thomas Jefferson's fossil collection and plant samples gathered by Lewis and Clark. The collection also includes 73,000 **holotype specimens**: preserved samples scientists use as references for defining and naming species. Drexel said it would preserve access for students and researchers, but access for the general public remains unclear.

Less than a week before the closing date, the William Penn Foundation offered one year of bridge funding. Bridge funding is temporary financial support that provides time to explore a lasting solution. Drexel said it was exploring possible work with the foundation but needed a plan for long-term **sustainability** before considering reopening.

Philadelphia's city council proposed **zoning** changes to make selling the museum building or converting it to other uses more difficult. It also plans public hearings to investigate how the closure happened and consider possible solutions. Whether the museum will reopen remains uncertain.

Word Treasure

specimens -- Samples preserved for scientific study.

holotype -- A reference specimen used to define and name a species.

revenue -- Money an organization receives.

sustainability -- The ability to keep operating over the long term.

zoning -- Rules about how land and buildings may be used.

Background you need

The Academy first displayed a dinosaur skeleton in 1868.

Bridge funding provides temporary support while lasting solutions are explored.

Break it down

Introduces the closure and the Academy's historical milestones.

Describes family visits following the announcement.

Explains financial pressures and presents criticism alongside Drexel's response.

Describes scientific collections and uncertainty about public access.

Explains the funding offer, reopening conditions and city council proposals.

Why it matters

The museum has provided families with opportunities to learn about natural history and holds specimens used for scientific study. Its closure raises questions about public access and how it could operate in the future.

Test what you remember

1. When did the Academy open to the public?
 - (A) In 1828
 - (B) In 1812
 - (C) In 2011
 - (D) In 1868
2. How did revenue in the final weeks compare with last September?
 - (A) It was more than 20 times higher.
 - (B) It stayed at the same level.
 - (C) It was about twice as high.
 - (D) It fell to about half as much.
3. What are holotype specimens used for?
 - (A) Counting and tracking visitors
 - (B) Setting and checking budgets
 - (C) Planning and building exhibits
 - (D) Defining and naming species
4. What was the purpose of the offered bridge funding?
 - (A) To allow staff to launch overseas museums
 - (B) To allow students to collect new fossils
 - (C) To allow space to install larger exhibits
 - (D) To allow time to explore lasting solutions
5. What did Drexel say it needed before considering reopening?
 - (A) A plan for collecting more fossils
 - (B) A plan for a new dinosaur display
 - (C) A plan for moving to another city
 - (D) A plan for long-term sustainability
6. What would the city council's proposed zoning changes make harder?
 - (A) Studying or naming the preserved species
 - (B) Offering or accepting temporary funding
 - (C) Selling or converting the museum building
 - (D) Counting or recording the museum visitors

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: D 4: D 5: D 6: C

1. Alexandria McCormick: She said childhood visits inspired her love of natural history and expressed sadness that her children might not have similar experiences.
2. Drexel University: It cited rising costs and declining attendance, affirmed its commitment to the Academy's legacy, and said reopening required a sustainable long-term plan.